

## SUCCESS STORIES

# How Digital Technology went to the Countryside

The Gyandoot project ([www.gyandoot.net](http://www.gyandoot.net)) has really helped the villagers of MP's tribal hinterland in making their lives simpler and by benefiting them economically. Here are a few of the success stories that abound.

### The house that Gyandoot built

On June 21, 2000, Kamalabai, a poor tribal lady from Dantoli village of Sardarpur development block, complained through a kiosk that the entire sanctioned amount through the Indira housing scheme had not been disbursed to her. At that stage, her cottage was half built and the rainy season was looming large.

Merely seven days after her complaint had been sent, an officer came for ground verification and completion of all other formalities. The sarpanch then gave her the remaining amount and she was able to complete her home before the rains began.

### Bride through kiosk

Mohanlal and Suraj Khati of Bagdi village are two unmarried young men. They came to know about the 'online matrimonial' facility available

at soochanalayas.

They came independently to the soochanalayas and registered themselves to scan the available data of young women for a bride of their choice. Imagine their joy when each found the girl of his dreams. The hitch? Both of them liked the same girl from Dhar. Now, both are competing to reach out to the girl's parents. *Kaun banega pati?*

### Online transaction? Sure!

A cow for Rs 3,000. This is the first real e-commerce transaction in the rural area of the tribal district. Kalsingh of Mirjapur village wanted to sell his cow. He registered at the soochanalaya of nearby Gunavad village to put up his offer of the animal online. He received four trade enquiries on his account and he finally sold his cow to the highest bidder, Premnarayan of Dilawara village. The auction facility of the Gyandoot enables trading of commodities like milch animals, cultivable land, tractors, agricultural tools, etc, creating a virtual marketplace to benefit villagers.

to ensure that the RTCs provided to the farmers are up-to-date. It also allows printing of land records as and when required. All changes to the land records database are done on the computer itself, to ensure that data on the computer remain current with time.

The Bhoomi software also has the provision of scanning original change orders of the revenue inspectors (the persons authorised to pass orders for adding or removing markings in land records) and the notices served on interested parties. Both documents are scanned. This ensures that in the future the responsibility can be fixed on the revenue inspector by showing the original documents signed by him, and also ensures that the interested parties cannot claim in the court that they were not served with the notice before the mutation.

The software incorporates a state-of-the-art bio-logon metrics system from Compaq, which authenticates various users on the Bhoomi software on the basis of their fingerprint. This also adds an additional security aspect to the whole process.

The other useful aspect of Bhoomi is that it enables administrators to generate various reports on the types of soil, the number of landowners owning land above a certain average, type of crops grown in a taluka, etc. This information enables administrators to take informed decisions for policy-making.

## The loopholes

But everything isn't quite rosy. Presently, steps in e-governance are based on the initiatives of certain government officers or state governments. The Central government is yet to talk of e-governance at the highest level. Worse, implementation suffers due to the lack of a unified body to monitor the whole process, and ensure that everyone is moving in the right direction. This is not surprising because seriously implementing e-governance calls for restructuring procedures as well as doing away with the existing system.

Again, even with computerisation in place, the success of e-governance still depends on people. True, you might not have to wait in a queue just to get a form, but the processing of the form still passes through the very same people who are in their present day seats. As Rajora says, "E-governance can be no replacement for good governance. For a successful e-governance project, technology plays only 15 per cent of the role, while management of the project plays 85 per cent of the role!" If management is in the hands of a few political, commercial and other elite groups, and they use this power to suit their purposes, e-governance will hardly benefit the common man.

Though there might be considerable enthusiasm at the individual level, driven by forward-looking individuals, things will not move in the right direction till the authorities take it upon themselves to implement it right. ■

## Karnataka: India's Silicon Valley

The Karnataka government has been taking some steps in the e-governance direction. We present details of some of the initiatives.

### Small Scale Industries

The state has computerised the permanent registration of over 2.5 lakh small-scale industries. All the districts as well as 26 taluka industry centres have been completely computerised.

### Zero-piracy territory

Karnataka has become the only state in the country and the first in the Asia-Pacific region to adopt a systematic approach to combat software piracy.

### Police IT 2000

The police department is already computerised to a large extent and has an ambitious project to enhance the capabilities of the intelligence wing.

At present, computers are used in several departments and such initiatives are taken in a decentralised manner. The government also proposes to establish a Centre for E-governance under the Department of Information Technology. This is likely to further fuel the process of IT adoption in the governance of the state.